



water during dry spells. Their foliage casts little shade to smother weeds, so careful weeding is needed. Earth up around the bulbs as they mature, to whiten them and provide frost protection.

HARVESTING AND STORING

The foliage can be used as a herb, in moderation, at any time. Bulbs will be big enough to harvest from early to late fall; lift them and discard unwanted foliage. Bulbs will stand in good condition for some weeks if earthed up outdoors or kept in the salad crisper of the refrigerator.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Generally, fennel has no significant pests or diseases and bolting is the most likely problem. Discourage this by sowing in summer when days are long and nights are mild, and by ensuring that the soil does not dry out. Bolt-resistant varieties are available.

One fungus that sometimes affects fennel is rhizoctonia, which stunts plant growth and causes colorful sores on both the bulb and the stem. This disease has no cure, so dig up and destroy any infected plants and practice crop rotation in future years.